

Hocking Hills Day Trip — From Columbus

A one-day plan from Columbus to Hocking Hills without the scramble. Leave early, hike the highlights, get home before dark.

How to use

1. Pick a **departure window** the night before (weather + traffic decide).
2. Choose **Route A** (classic parks loop) or **Route B** (fewer stops, more trail time).
3. Print this sheet or keep it offline — cell service drops in the gorge.

Pre-trip checklist (night before)

- ☐ Check park alerts / trail closures
- ☐ Fill gas in Columbus; pack water (2L+ per person)
- ☐ Download offline maps for the park cluster
- ☐ Pack shoes with grip, light layers, rain shell
- ☐ Cooler snacks + cash for small lots / tips
- ☐ Tell someone your return ETA
- ☐ Decide: one carpool or two cars (parking fills early)

Drive timing (Columbus → park cluster)

Window	Leave Columbus	Arrive parks (approx)	Notes
Early bird	6:30–7:00	~8:00–8:30	Best parking at Old Man's Cave
Standard	8:00–8:30	~9:30–10:00	Still workable weekdays
Late start	after 9:30	after 11:00	Expect full lots; have a backup trail

Drive is roughly **1–1.5 hours** depending on traffic south of town. Build a 20-minute buffer.

Route A — Classic highlights (most first-timers)

Time	Stop	Time on site	Notes
Arrive	Old Man's Cave / visitor area	90–120 min	Main gorge loop; restrooms + maps
Mid-morning	Ash Cave	30–45 min	Short walk; big payoff; often crowded
Midday	Lunch	45 min	Picnic tables or nearby town grab
Afternoon	Cedar Falls <i>or</i> Rock House	60–90 min	Pick one — don't rush both
3:30–4:00	Start return drive	—	Aim to be rolling before dusk

Rule: two solid stops beat four rushed ones.

Route B — Deeper hike day

Time	Plan
Arrive early	Old Man's Cave → Grandma Gatewood connector if open/conditions allow
Midday	Packed lunch on trail or at a quiet picnic area
Afternoon	One secondary stop only if energy remains
Leave by 3:30	Same return rule

Skip Ash Cave if lots are full and you already got gorge time.

Parking & logistics

- ☐ Have a **backup lot / trail** written below before you leave home
- ☐ Screenshot the park map and your return route
- ☐ Note restroom locations at the first stop
- ☐ Keep valuables out of sight; take keys/phone/wallet on trail
- ☐ Agree on a meetup pin if the group splits

Backup trail if primary lot is full: _____

Group meetup pin: _____

Weather & season swaps

Condition	Do this instead
Heavy rain / flash flood risk	Stay on high/short overlooks; postpone gorge bottom walks
Ice / freeze-thaw	Microspikes or cancel — sandstone gets slick
Peak fall color weekend	Leave by 6:00am; expect traffic both ways
Summer heat	Start earliest window; shade breaks every hour
Fog / low visibility	Delay departure 30–60 min; keep headlights on

Packing list (day pack)

- ☐ Water + electrolytes
- ☐ Trail snacks / lunch
- ☐ Rain shell
- ☐ Extra socks
- ☐ Headlamp (even for day trips)
- ☐ Small first-aid + blister kit
- ☐ Trash bag (pack out)
- ☐ Phone battery pack

- ☐ Printed or offline map

On-trail rules that prevent headaches

1. Stay on marked trails — sandstone edges crumble.
2. One person owns the timeline; everyone else follows.
3. Turn around with enough light and fuel for the drive home.
4. No drone / cliff-edge photos that make the group wait.

Return to Columbus

Milestone	Clock
Leave park area	:
Gas / bathroom stop	:
Arrive Columbus	:

Evening idea if energy remains: easy dinner on the south side of town — don't add another hike.

After-trip note (one line)

What I'd change next time: _____

Buckeye Trail Guide · Curated by Keith Householder · Columbus, Ohio

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